

Semantle Strategy Guide

Michael Clancy

09/03/2026

Understanding Similarity

In Semantle, you take turns guessing words and are told the ‘similarity’ of each guess to a hidden target word. Similarity is scored out of a maximum of 100, which only the target word matches, and you will be told the precise ranking of any guesses among the 1,000 most similar words to the target. It is important to note that words similar to the target are not necessarily similar to each other. One of the easier and more effective ways to approach the similarity score of a guess is to think: “How likely would I be to read a sentence where the guessed word was substituted for the target word.” This means that similarity can behave differently than we might expect. For example, words with exactly opposite meanings to the target, like the guess ‘good’ for the target ‘bad,’ may have very close similarity scores because we use these words in very similar sentences (“I had a good day” or “I had a bad day”). It also means that guesses related to the target but of different parts of speech, i.e. ‘runner’ and ‘running’ for ‘run,’ may have lower scores, since we don’t say that you “go for a running.” This idea doesn’t express similarity perfectly as the game calculates it, but it’s a strong framework to keep in mind as you play.

Playing the Game

It’s easiest to approach a game of Semantle by breaking it down into three stages of play—beginning, middle and end. Depending on the target word, these stages may occur at different similarity scores, so this guide uses the top 1,000 as a universal benchmark.

There is no starting word given, so begin the game by guessing several different words to build a profile of the target for later use. Negative scores usually indicate dissimilar types of words to the target, but otherwise at this stage focusing too much on the similarity of guesses can reduce the breadth of new guesses. Starting guesses should generally be as dissimilar as possible, changing from among concepts, associations, and major parts of speech (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs). Continue in this manner until a word is guessed that is among the 1,000 most similar words. If this stalls, the target may not be precisely related to its similar words. Guess several prepositions, interjections, and conjunctions to ensure the target is not in one of these categories.

Once one or more of the 1,000 most similar words has been identified, begin narrowing down the scope of the potential target with words from phrases and sentences containing the most similar already guessed words. At this stage it may be helpful to use the early guesses to identify the precise

part of speech of the target; be sure to try both singular and plural forms. If this strategy does not yield substantially more similar answers after 15+ guesses, consider alternative uses or definitions of these guesses to what you may be using. Continue until there is at least one guess with a top 200 similarity score.

At this point, one or more guesses should be quite close to the target. If the target's part of speech has not already been identified, guessing variations on the most similar word should accomplish this. Look for commonalities among the most similar guesses and finally consider synonyms, antonyms, and superior or subordinate verbs or nouns (i.e. 'run' for 'move,' since running is a type of moving). The game will conclude once the exact target word is guessed.